

POSC 459: Social Welfare Politics and Policy

Fall 2026

Faculty Information

Instructor: David P. Adams, Ph.D.

Office: 516 Gordon Hall

Phone/Text: (657) 278-4770

Email: dpadams@fullerton.edu

Website: dadams.io

Office Hours: Mondays and Wednesdays, [TBD], and by [appointment](#).

Schedule meetings: dadams.io/appointments

Course Communication

All course announcements and communications will be sent via *Canvas* and university email. Students are responsible for regularly checking their *Canvas* notifications and email, and for ensuring that Canvas notifications are set to receive course messages. Students are expected to check *Canvas* and their email at least once daily.

Response time: I will strive to respond to all student emails and *Canvas* messages within 24 hours, except on weekends and holidays. If you have not received a response within 24 hours, please send a follow-up message. If you are still waiting after 48 hours, contact me via phone or SMS at (657) 278-4770.

Technical Problems

If you encounter any technical difficulties, contact the instructor immediately to document the problem. Then contact: [student IT help desk](#), [email](#), phone (657) 278-8888, walk-in [student genius center](#), or online chat via the [portal](#) (“Online IT Help” then “Live Chat”).

For issues with Canvas: Canvas Support Hotline = (657) 278-8888, [search the CSUF Canvas Guides](#), or [report a problem](#).

Alternative submission: If you cannot submit an assignment via *Canvas*, contact the professor as soon as possible to document the issue and arrange an alternative.

Course Information

Prefix, number, title: POSC 459, *Social Welfare Politics and Policy*

Meeting times: In-Person, Monday & Wednesday, 1:00–2:15 p.m., [Room TBD]

Units: 3 **Schedule Code:** [TBD]

Course requisite(s): POSC 100 or graduate standing

Catalog description: American social policies—welfare, Social Security, health care—and the political environment in which they exist. Origins, implementation, and reforms of current social policies, emphasizing questions of effectiveness and policy improvement.

Policy regarding the use of generative AI: See the *Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology* section below.

Course materials and equipment: Canvas; access to course readings; laptop recommended

Required texts: Howard (2007); Campbell (2014); Desmond (2023); plus ebook readings through Pollak Library (see *Required Texts* below)

Course Description

This course is an intensive introduction to U.S. social welfare policy and politics. It has four parts: the big picture (who are the poor, and how did the welfare state develop?); the programs (social insurance, the safety net, tax expenditures); two case studies in major reform (welfare reform and the ACA); and the political forces that shape all of it (public opinion, interest groups, race, and gender).

The course moves between levels of analysis. Comparative welfare state theory sits alongside individual family narratives; legislative history sits alongside street-level program design. Both matter. You cannot understand why TANF looks the way it does without understanding the politics that produced it, and you cannot evaluate whether the ACA succeeded without understanding what it was actually trying to accomplish.

This course is taught from a political science and policy analysis perspective. Political science helps explain *why* we get the policies we get; policy analysis helps evaluate *whether those policies do what they claim*. Both lenses are at work throughout the semester.

Student Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

1. Describe the core architecture of the U.S. welfare state: social insurance, public assistance, tax expenditures, and public-private arrangements.
2. Trace the political development of major programs (Social Security, TANF, Medicaid, ACA) and connect that history to current policy debates.
3. Apply key concepts from political science and policy analysis to evaluate welfare programs: policy feedback, institutional design, interest group politics, and public opinion.
4. Analyze how race and gender have structured both program design and access to benefits.
5. Situate U.S. welfare policy within a comparative frame and explain the sources of American exceptionalism.
6. Construct an evidence-based policy argument using primary sources and scholarly literature.

Required Texts

The following are available for purchase at the Titan bookstore:

1. Howard, Christopher. 2007. *The Welfare State Nobody Knows: Debunking Myths About U.S. Social Policy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.
2. Campbell, Andrea Louise. 2014. *Trapped in America's Safety Net: One Family's Struggle*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
3. Desmond, Matthew. 2023. *Poverty, by America*. New York, NY: Crown.

Required Texts Available as Ebooks at Pollak Library

1. Rank, Mark Robert, Lawrence M. Eppard, and Heather E. Bullock. 2021. *Poorly Understood: What America Gets Wrong About Poverty*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=6461413>
2. Howard, Christopher. 2022. *Who Cares: The Social Safety Net in America*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?pq-origsite=primo&docID=7099798>
3. Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. 2016. *Healthcare Reform and American Politics: What Everyone Needs to Know*, 3rd ed. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=4310736>
4. Beland, David, Kimberly J. Morgan, and Christopher Howard, eds. 2015. *The Oxford Handbook of U.S. Social Policy*. Oxford University Press.
<https://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/fullerton/detail.action?docID=1825907>

Additional Readings

Additional readings—articles, book chapters, policy documents, and documentary viewing guides—are posted on Canvas and noted in the course schedule. Canvas readings are required and carry equal weight to book readings.

Student Resources Website

It is the student's responsibility to read and understand the required and important [student information for course syllabi](#). Included is information about:

- University learning goals and General Education learning objectives
- Students' rights to accommodations
- Campus student support resources and academic integrity
- Emergency preparedness; library and IT services
- Software privacy, accessibility statement, diversity statement, and land acknowledgement

- Final exam schedule and semester calendar

Course Requirements

Course Format

This is an in-person lecture and discussion course meeting twice weekly for 75 minutes. Students complete assigned readings before class; class time is divided between lecture, structured discussion, and periodic documentary screenings. Three weeks are structured as asynchronous work weeks with no in-person meetings (see below).

Three Asynchronous Weeks

Three weeks are designated asynchronous. There are no in-person meetings those weeks. Students complete assigned readings, watch a designated documentary, and submit a Canvas response by that Friday at 11:59 p.m. Specific instructions will be posted to Canvas in advance.

- **Week 4 (Async):** Political development of the welfare state; *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2
- **Week 9 (Async):** Welfare reform; *Two American Families*
- **Week 14 (Async):** Public opinion and interest groups; term papers and grad outlines due

Graded Work

- **Required for all students (60% total):** Attendance and Participation (10%); Discussion Papers, 5 of 10 (10%); Midterm Exam (20%); Final Exam (20%).
- **Undergraduates only (40% total):**
 - **Policy Brief (20%):** A 3–4 page analysis of one program: OASDI, SSI, TANF, Unemployment Insurance, Medicaid, Medicare, SNAP, or the EITC. Cover the program's stated purpose, who it serves, its major design features, and one significant reform debate. Academic writing conventions and source citations required.

- **Term Paper (20%):** A 6–8 page research paper building on the policy brief. Analyze the political and policy-relevant strengths and weaknesses of your program and develop a reform proposal, drawing on course concepts and the program's political history.
- **Graduate students only (40% total):**
 - **Research Proposal (10%):** Topic, research question, and preliminary bibliography.
 - **Introduction/Outline/Annotated Bibliography (10%):** Substantial revision from the proposal with clear research design and sources.
 - **Final Research Paper (20%):** A 10–15 page original research paper submitted during finals week.

Graduate Student Requirements

Graduate students complete all readings including graduate-only readings posted on Canvas. They take both the midterm and final exams and write five discussion papers. In place of the undergraduate policy brief and term paper, graduate students complete a scaffolded 10–15 page original research paper sequence with staged feedback and revision across three milestones:

1. **Research Proposal (10%)** (1–2 pages): Due Week 10, October 28.
 - Identify policy topic, core research question, and why the question matters for welfare politics/policy.
 - Include a working thesis or argument direction.
 - Include a preliminary bibliography (minimum 6 credible sources, including scholarly sources).
 - Instructor feedback will focus on scope, feasibility, and argument focus.
2. **Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography (10%):** Due Week 14, December 2.
 - Revised introduction with clear thesis and paper roadmap.
 - Detailed section outline showing claim flow and supporting evidence for each section.

- Annotated bibliography with brief annotations describing each source's argument and relevance to your project.
- Substantial revision from the proposal is expected; this milestone should show a sharpened question and stronger evidence base.

3. Final Research Paper (20%) (10–15 pages): Due during finals week.

- Original analysis that synthesizes course concepts, scholarly literature, and policy evidence.
- Clear argument structure (thesis, evidence, analysis, counterargument/limitations, conclusion).
- Proper citation and academic writing conventions.
- The final submission should directly incorporate and respond to feedback from Milestones 1 and 2.

Grading Policies and Standards

a. Grading scale: See Table 1 for the full letter-grade percentage scale used in this course.

Table 1: Grade scale

Grade	Percent	Grade	Percent
A+	98.0–100.0	C+	77.0–79.9
A	93.0–97.9	C	73.0–76.9
A-	90.0–92.9	C-	70.0–72.9
B+	87.0–89.9	D+	67.0–69.9
B	83.0–86.9	D	63.0–66.9
B-	80.0–82.9	D-	60.0–62.9
		F	0.0–59.9

b. Required course assignments (undergraduate): See Table 2 for undergraduate assignment weights and due dates.

See Table 3 for graduate assignment weights and due dates.

Table 2: Undergraduate assignment weighting

Assignment	Weight	Due
Attendance and Participation	10%	Ongoing
Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)	10%	See schedule
Midterm Exam	20%	Wednesday, October 14
Policy Brief	20%	Wednesday, October 28
Term Paper	20%	Wednesday, December 2
Final Exam	20%	Finals Week
Total	100%	

Table 3: Graduate assignment weighting

Assignment	Weight	Due
Attendance and Participation	10%	Ongoing
Discussion Papers (5 x 2%)	10%	See schedule
Midterm Exam	20%	Wednesday, October 14
Research Proposal	10%	Wednesday, October 28
Introduction, Outline, and Annotated Bibliography	10%	Wednesday, December 2
Final Research Paper	20%	Finals Week
Final Exam	20%	Finals Week
Total	100%	

c. Attendance and participation policy: Students are expected to attend all in-person sessions. If you are unable to attend, notify the professor in advance. You are responsible for obtaining any materials or information covered during absences. Participation in in-class activities cannot be made up.

d. Examination dates:

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Final Exam: Finals week; exact date and time assigned by Registrar (December 14–18)

e. Make-up and late submission policy: All assignments are due on the date specified in the course schedule. Extensions must be requested in writing before the due date and will be granted only for illness or other documented unforeseen circumstances. Late work without an approved extension loses one-third of a letter grade per calendar day.

Alternative procedures for submitting work: Students are expected to submit all written work via *Canvas*. Exams are taken in person. If you cannot submit via *Canvas*, contact the professor immediately to arrange an alternative.

f. Authentication of student work: Students may be required to submit their work to a plagiarism detection service. Cal State Fullerton uses Turnitin®. Students should be aware that submitted work may be checked for authenticity and originality.

g. Extra credit: There are no extra credit assignments in this course.

h. Retention of student work: Work submitted for a grade, whether as a hard copy or through Canvas, shall be retained for a reasonable time after the semester ends, not to exceed the last day of the subsequent semester. Students have the right to review graded work in the presence of the instructor. (UPS 320.005)

Academic Integrity

Students are expected to adhere to the highest standards of academic integrity. Any student found to have engaged in academic dishonesty will be subject to the sanctions described in the [Academic Dishonesty Policy](#) (UPS 300.021). Academic dishonesty includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, fabrication, facilitating academic dishonesty, and submitting previously graded work without prior authorization. Students are expected to be familiar with the university's policy and to adhere to it in all aspects of this course.

Policy on the Use of Generative AI and Other Technology

Generative AI (including large language models, image generators, and other tools) is permitted in this course, but use must be transparent, intentional, and in service of learning. The core principle is simple: **you must do the intellectual work of this course**. AI can amplify your thinking, but not replace it.

Permitted uses:

- Brainstorming and outlining arguments
- Explaining concepts you don't understand (then explaining it back in your own words)
- Literature searching and summarizing sources
- Editing, proofreading, and revising your work
- Sanity-checking your analysis or logic

- Generating synthetic examples or test cases for your ideas

Not permitted:

- Using AI to generate your analysis, arguments, or conclusions
- Submitting AI-generated text as your own writing
- Using AI to avoid engaging with course concepts or readings
- Letting AI do the intellectual heavy lifting (interpreting sources, building arguments, synthesizing ideas)

Disclosure requirement:

If you use generative AI tools in ways beyond basic editing, you must disclose your use. Include a brief note at the end of your assignment explaining what tools you used and how (e.g., “I used Claude to help organize my outline and check the logic of my argument in Section 3”). This is not a confession—it’s transparency about your process.

What this means:

The goal of this course is for *you* to learn to think like a policy analyst and to develop your own informed arguments about welfare policy. AI is a tool that can enhance that learning if used thoughtfully. Using it to avoid thinking will undermine your own education and violates academic integrity. Questions about what constitutes appropriate use? Ask before you submit.

Technical Competencies

Students need:

- Proficiency with Canvas, including submitting assignments and accessing course materials
- Ability to use university email and Canvas messages for course communication
- Basic word processing skills and ability to export documents to PDF

Calendar of Topics / Schedule of Classes

We will follow the schedule below as closely as possible. If adjustments are needed, you will receive advance notice in class and on *Canvas*.

Key: (Pollak) = Pollak Library eBook **Reading structure:** Core Readings are required. Recommended Readings are optional but encouraged. Grad Extension Readings are required for graduate students.

Important dates:

- Midterm Exam: Wednesday, October 14 (in-class)
- Policy Briefs / Graduate Proposals due: Wednesday, October 28
- Term Papers / Graduate Outlines due: Wednesday, December 2
- Final Exam: Finals week, December 14–18 (Registrar-assigned)
- Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27 (no class)
- Async Weeks: Week 4 (Sep 14–16), Week 9 (Oct 19–21), Week 14 (Nov 30–Dec 2)

PART I: The Big Picture

8/24 – Week 1: Introduction — What Is the American Welfare State?

Readings

- Campbell, chapters 1–2: “Trying to Make it in America” & “Down the Rabbit Hole”
- Desmond, chapter 1: “The Kind of Problem Poverty Is”

Film (assigned for async viewing; Canvas response due Friday 8/28)

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 1 (PBS Frontline, 2020, 54 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/growing-up-poor-in-america/>

9/1 – Week 2: Why Are So Many Americans Poor?

Readings

- Howard, chapter 2: “Tracks of My Tiers”
- Desmond, chapter 2: “Why Haven’t We Made More Progress?”
- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section 1: “Who Are the Poor?” pp. 15–49 (Pollak)

9/7 – Week 3: American Exceptionalism?

Monday September 7 is Labor Day — no class. Wednesday September 9 only.

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 1: “She So Unusual”
- Desmond, chapters 3–4: “How We Undercut Workers” & “How We Force the Poor to Pay More”

Grad Extension Readings

- Esping-Andersen, Gosta. 1990. *The Three Worlds of Welfare Capitalism*, chapter 1
- Hacker, Jacob S. 2004. “Privatizing Risk without Privatizing the Welfare State.” *APSR* 98(2): 243–260

9/14 – Week 4: ASYNC — Political Development of the Welfare State

No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, September 18. Canvas response due Friday 11:59 p.m.

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 3: “Twice in a Lifetime”
- Pierson, Paul. 1995. *Dismantling the Welfare State*, chapters 1–2

Grad Extension Readings

- Pierson, Paul. 1993. "When Effect Becomes Cause: Policy Feedback and Political Change." *World Politics* 45(4): 595–628
- Baumgartner, Frank and Bryan Jones. 2009. *Agendas and Instability in American Politics*, 2nd ed., chapters 1–3

Film

- *Growing Up Poor in America*, Part 2 (PBS Frontline, 2021, 54 min.)

PART II: Programs of the Welfare State

9/21 – Week 5: Social Security and Medicare

Readings

- Berkowitz, Edward D. and Larry DeWitt. "Social Security," chapter 15 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Oberlander, Jonathan. "Medicare," chapter 17 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)
- Greszler, Rachel. 2021. "Seven Hard Truths Americans Should Know about Social Security." Heritage Foundation Issue Brief 5212
- Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. 2018. "Top Ten Facts about Social Security"

Assignments

- Policy brief topic selection due Monday September 21 (brief Canvas post)

9/28 – Week 6: The Safety Net, Part 1 — TANF, SNAP, and the EITC

Core Readings

- Howard, chapter 5: “Programs for the Poor are not Always Poor Programs”
- Campbell, chapter 3: “The Place of the Poor in the American Welfare State”
- Desmond, chapter 5: “How We Rely on Welfare”
- Gitterman, Daniel. “The Politics of Supporting Low-Wage Workers,” chapter 21 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Recommended Readings

- Gundersen, Craig. “Food Assistance Programs and Food Security,” chapter 22 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

10/5 – Week 7: The Safety Net, Part 2 — Housing, Income, and Medicaid

Readings

- Howard, *Who Cares*, chapters 5–7: “Income”; “Food”; “Housing” (Pollak)
- Grogan, Colleen M. and Christina M. Andrews. “Medicaid,” chapter 19 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

10/12 – Week 8: Midterm Review and Midterm Exam

Monday October 12: midterm review. Wednesday October 14: **MIDTERM EXAM** (in-class).

PART III: Case Studies in Reform

10/19 – Week 9: ASYNC — Welfare Reform

No in-person meetings. Complete readings and film by Friday, October 23. Canvas response due Friday 11:59 p.m.

Core Readings

- Campbell, chapters 4–5
- Beland, Daniel and Alex Waddan. 2012. “Welfare Reform,” chapter 2 in *The Politics of Policy Change*
- Rank et al., *Poorly Understood*, Section IV: “Does Welfare Work?” pp. 116–145 (Pollak)

Recommended Readings

- Semuels, Alana. 2016. “The End of Welfare as We Know It.” *The Atlantic*
- Rector, Robert, Jamie Hall, and Leslie Ford. 2022. “A Road Map for Conservative, Pro-Family Welfare Reform.” Heritage Foundation

Grad Extension Readings

- Soss, Joe and Sanford F. Schram. 2007. “A Public Transformed? Welfare Reform as Policy Feedback.” *APSR* 101(1)

Film

- *Two American Families* (PBS Frontline, 2013, 60 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/two-american-families/>

10/26 – Week 10: Health Care Reform and the ACA

Readings

- Jacobs, Lawrence and Theda Skocpol. *Healthcare Reform and American Politics*, chapters 1–4 (Pollak)
- Hacker, Jacob. 2010. “The Road to Somewhere: Why Health Reform Happened.” *Perspectives on Politics* 8(3): 861–876

Assignments

- Policy Briefs due Wednesday October 28 (undergraduates)
- Research Proposals due Wednesday October 28 (graduate students)

11/2 – Week 11: Documentary Screening and Synthesis Discussion

This week steps back from the reading cycle for structured documentary discussion and synthesis across Parts I–III. Review your notes before class.

Film (in-class or assigned in advance)

- *Poverty, Politics and Profit* (PBS Frontline, 2017, 54 min.)
<https://www.pbs.org/wgbh/frontline/documentary/poverty-politics-and-profit/>

Assignments

- Discussion paper prompt 4 posted this week (tied to welfare reform and ACA units)

PART IV: Political Forces Shaping the Welfare State

11/9 – Week 12: Race and the Welfare State, Part 1

Monday November 9 only — November 11 is Veterans Day; no class.

Readings

- Howard, chapter 9: “Race Still Matters”
- Gilens, Martin. 1999. *Why Americans Hate Welfare*, chapter 5 (skim chapters 1 and 3)

11/16 – Week 13: Race Part 2 and Gender and the Welfare State

Core Readings

- Michener, Jamil. 2020. “Race, Politics and the Affordable Care Act.” *Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law* 45(4): 547–566
- Mettler, Suzanne. 1998. *Dividing Citizens: Gender and Federalism in New Deal Public Policy*, chapters 1, 5–6

Recommended Readings

- Morgan, Kimberly J. 2013. “Policies for Work/Life Balance in the United States.” *Informations Sociales* 177: 60–71
- Gornick, Janet C. and Natascia Boeri. “Gender and Poverty,” chapter 10 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Thanksgiving Break: November 23–27. No class.

11/30 – Week 14: ASYNC — Public Opinion and Interest Groups

No in-person meetings. Canvas response due Friday December 4, 11:59 p.m.

Readings

- Howard, chapter 6: “Shaq is Still Pretty Tall: Public Support for the American Welfare State”
- Howard, chapter 7: “The World According to AARP”
- Desmond, chapter 6: “How We Buy Opportunity”
- Howard, *Who Cares*: “Business and Labor” (Pollak)

Assignments

- **Term Papers due Wednesday December 2 (undergraduates)**
- **Graduate Introductions, Outlines, and Annotated Bibliographies due Wednesday December 2**

12/7 – Week 15: Solutions and Course Synthesis

Core Readings

- Campbell, chapter 6: “The Future of America’s Means-Tested Programs”
- Desmond, chapters 7–8

Recommended Readings

- Desmond, chapters 9–10
- Piven, Frances Fox and Lorraine C. Minnite. “Poor People’s Politics,” chapter 33 in *Oxford Handbook* (Pollak)

Assignments

- Wednesday December 9: Final exam review

12/14 – Week 16: Finals Week

Deliverables

- **Final Exam:** Date and time assigned by Registrar (December 14–18)
- **Graduate Final Research Papers due:** Same date as Final Exam